fined or exiled, and were not allowed to serve in the imperial service. And although heretics who persisted in gathering followers and teaching them were threatened with “the sharp goads of a more severe punishment,” this was rarely carried out.[3]

Nor had there been, in the previous centuries, any large-scale effort to hunt down heretics and execute them. Teachers who published and gathered students, such as Peter Abelard, often drew the notice of their fellow priests, but like Abelard they were usually threatened with imprisonment and financial loss, not death.*

But in the previous century, heresies had begun to spring up, particularly across the south of Francia, with renewed vigor.

Most often, these heresies were the teachings not of academics or priests but of charismatic laypeople who gathered larger and larger popular followings. These charismatic heretics had different preoccupations, but at some point all of them made the same claim: the organized Church was fallen and corrupt and had nothing to do with true spiritual life. In Milan, a band of dissidents claimed that the Holy Spirit visited them daily, making priests and pope completely unnecessary. At Cologne, a small group of rebels against Rome began to preach that “he who sits in the Chair of Peter has lost the power to ordain,” because the papacy had been “corrupted through involvement in secular business.” In the last quarter of the twelfth century, a wandering preacher named Peter Waldo gathered an enormous following by preaching that the Church hierarchy was corrupt, that priests ought to give up their positions and work with their hands, and that it was “a bad thing to found and endow churches and monasteries.” His followers, known as the Waldensians, traveled through the French countryside, preaching a stripped-down, evangelical-style gospel of repentance: “They say,” writes the thirteenth-century chronicler Reinerius Saccho, “that the doctrine of Christ . . . is sufficient for salvation without the statutes of the church.”[4]

None of this was good news for the pope, but until the fall of Constantinople, the attentions of Rome had been focused farther to the east. And the locals were often tolerant of the heretics. “Why do you not expel these people and shun them?” a priest in southern Francia demanded of a local knight. “We cannot do that,” the knight answered, “for we were raised with them, and we have relatives among them, and we see that they lead honest and decent lives.”[5]

But with the Crusades once again failing, Innocent III was willing to look closer to home. And the heresy now flourishing in the south was stronger and more radical than any seen before. The believers called themselves the Pure Ones: in Greek, *katharos*; to the church they opposed, the Cathars. Cathar